Our melody

Level 2 · Lesson 2 · invent, play and present

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For: ages 9 to 14, in groups of 4 or 5. **Length:** 50 minutes.

What they learn: to invent a short melody, play it to the pulse, choose its instrument and present it.

What you need: the classroom computer, ideally one per group, and a sheet with the 16-box grid for each group. It helps to have done Level 1 first.

The trick that makes everything sound good: use only five keys, `Z` `X` `C` `B` `N` (C, D, E, G, A). With these five notes any combination sounds musical: nobody can "get it wrong".

What's new in this lesson: rhythm. Besides one note per beat ("ta"), pupils discover that two notes fit into one beat ("ti-ti") and that one note can last two beats ("ta-a").

The lesson, step by step

1 Try it out

5 min

Open the Cosmic Keyboard. Play the five keys and a few random combinations. The class checks that everything sounds good.

2 Rhythm with words

8 min

Switch on the metronome (**pulse**, **tap**, slow). Clap four beats saying "ta, ta, ta, ta"; the class repeats. Then "ta, ta, ti-ti, ta": the two claps of "ti-ti" are quick, inside a single beat. Then "ta, ta, ta-a": the "a" stretches one more beat.

With words: "Sun, Sun, Ma-ry, Sun". *Sun* is one beat; *Ma-ry*, two notes in one beat.

Finally, a single key (`Z`) played with that rhythm. Look at the three note values further down.

3 Invent

15 min

Each group invents a melody of 4 bars of 4 beats and writes it in the grid. First with quarter notes only (one letter per box). Then they may change **up to two boxes** into eighth notes: split the box with a diagonal line and put one letter on each side. At the end, the last note can be a half note: `Z` and a dash in the next box, so the melody "stays at home".

4 Play to the pulse

10 min

With the metronome slow, the class first says the melody's syllables out loud. Then one pupil from each group plays it; the others clap the pulse.

5 Dress it up

4 min

Each group chooses an instrument from the Keyboard list —violin, flute, voice, marimba...— and listens to how their melody changes.

6 Present

8 min

Each group plays its melody to the class and records it with the Keyboard's ● **wav** button.

"What did you like? What feeling does it give you?"

How to tell it worked: each group has its grid written out with at least one box of eighth notes, says its syllables to the pulse, plays it through to the end and saves its recording.

The three note values



Quarter note

«ta»

1 note in 1 beat.
Press the key with the click.

In the grid: `C`



Two eighth notes

«ti-ti»

2 notes in 1 beat.
One with the click, the other halfway between.

In the grid: `C` `B`



Half note

«ta-a»

1 note that lasts 2 beats.
Press and hold for one more click.

In the grid: `Z` `–`

The keys and their notes

Z	X	C	V	B	N	M
C	D	E	F	G	A	B

This lesson uses the five highlighted keys: Z X C B N (C, D, E, G, A). V (F) and M (B) are kept for later.

Note names: *C = do · D = re · E = mi · F = fa · G = sol · A = la · B = si. Both names mean the same note.*

An example

Bar	beat 1	beat 2	beat 3	beat 4
1	C	X	Z	X
	ta	*ta*	*ta*	*ta*
2	C	C / B	N	B
	ta	*ti-ti*	*ta*	*ta*
3	N	B / C	X	C
	ta	*ti-ti*	*ta*	*ta*
4	X / C	X	Z	–
	ti-ti	*ta*	*ta-*	*-a*

How to read it: each box is one click of the metronome. A single letter = “ta”. A box split by the diagonal = “ti-ti”: first the top letter, then the bottom one, both within the same click. The dash = the previous note keeps sounding (“ta-a”).
Before playing: the class says the syllables out loud with the metronome — “ta ta ta ta · ta ti-ti ta ta · ta ti-ti ta ta · ti-ti ta ta-a” — and then plays them on the keys `Z` `X` `C` `B` `N`.

To go further: pupils who want to can write their melody on the staff with the Score, following part 2 of Exercise no. 1.

These lessons are a starting point. Each teacher can design the examples to suit their own class. For our part, we will keep adding lesson topics according to the requests we receive through the contact form.

The group's grid

Bar	beat 1	beat 2	beat 3	beat 4
1				
2				
3				
4				

One letter per box (Z X C B N) · split box = “ti-ti” · dash = “ta-a”. Write the syllables underneath.

✂ cut out and take home

Listen to your child's melody

For parents · 10 minutes · no music knowledge needed

Today in class your child invented a melody with their group. Ask them to play it for you:

1. Open the keyboard on the computer: **musicmotionsuite.com/apps/mmk-demo.html**
2. Your child plays the melody from their grid and teaches you the syllables: “ta” is one note in one beat, “ti-ti” is two quick notes in one beat, “ta-a” is a long note. Say them together. What feeling does the melody give you?
3. Choose another instrument from the list together and listen to it again.
4. If you like, record it with the ● **wav** button and send it to the teacher.

No sign-up or installation needed. The recording stays on your computer until you decide to send it.

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